How India Sets the Global Standard for Elections

Asha Jadeja Motwani



In a pivotal year for democracy worldwide, India stands out as a model for conducting free, fair, and high-quality elections. Some Indians may take for granted the status they enjoy in this regard, so let us take a closer look at the picture.

2024 is being called a super-election year globally. Over 70 countries are bringing their people to the polls, and the stakes are high. Nations with crucial elections range from the United States and Mexico to Algeria, South Korea, and more. Voters in the EU are choosing members of the European Parliament as well. Meanwhile, India — the world's largest democracy by far, with nearly twice as many people as the US and EU combined — will, of course, elect delegates to the Lok Sabha and other bodies this spring. And these elections will be grounded in the world's most robust electoral systems overall.

Although other nations have laws and procedures to address specific issues in the integrity of elections, none have taken the comprehensive approach we find in India. This is hardly a coincidence. From the day when independence was won, it was clear that such a sprawling and diverse country would need a strong framework for assuring that democratic rule could work properly. Therefore, the foundations were put in place, and they have been expanded and updated constantly ever since.

Start with effective separation of powers in the union government. The independent Election Commission sets the ground rules for elections in all states and territories—a marked contrast to, say, the US, where there are battles over different systems in the various states—while India's Supreme Court exerts a firm independent hand in deciding what's right and what is not. Both entities have played key roles over the years.

Through the ECI, India became a world leader in issuing voter ID cards and in the large-scale adoption of electronic voting machines (now backed up by paper audit trails). For this year's elections, about 1 million polling stations throughout India will provide convenient, well-supervised access to the vote, which is a feature not always found in democracies elsewhere. Also, when the Supreme Court recently ruled the electoral bond system to be unconstitutional, the decision was taken against the wishes of the ruling party and it won international praise. Reflecting on the Court's moves, Chris Murphy, a Senator from the United States, remarked, "India's efforts to reform campaign finance laws are commendable, setting a positive example for other democracies grappling with the influence of money in politics."

Next, consider a subject that runs deeper than rules and regulations. A democracy can only function well if people are well-informed and actually turn out to vote. Here too, India has set a global precedent with its SVEEP (Systematic Voters' Education and Electoral Participation) programmes. Launched in 2009, SVEEP has taken a proactive approach to getting voters involved. Tools for "gap analysis" have identified areas of under-participation in voter activity by age, gender, and location, with interventions then targeted to close the gaps. Thanks in large part to SVEEP, voter turnout has climbed since its 2009 low point, including turnout by women.

India's legislators also are working to bring women into the fold. Last year's bill to reserve one-third of Lok Sabha seats and state assembly seats for women was a major step, and fittingly it came while the country has a female president, a tribal woman no less in the person of Droupadi Murmu.

Finally, consider efforts to face democracy's digital challenges. Online misinformation is a problem in all countries, with deepfake visuals, bogus social-media posts and other forms of digital mischief aimed at swaying the political process. India is responding through a number of channels — for instance, by warning major online providers to keep their platforms clean or face consequences.

These steps run in parallel with India's continuing drive to build out its digital infrastructure. India Stack, first launched along with the Aadhaar ID initiative, is now hailed globally as a model for even highly developed nations. It has given millions of India's poorest citizens access to financial services from online banking to microloans, helping to create a society where all can be more self-sufficient and fully integrated with the life of the nation. That mission, in turn, provides a further bedrock of support for a democratically active society.

Despite being a very complex nation, India has built far-reaching democratic systems unlike any yet seen. These systems are sophisticated, accountable, transparent, and constantly being upgraded. The world's largest democracy has become arguably the strongest. At a time when people in many countries fear that democratic institutions are under attack, Indians can point to solutions by saying "LOOK AT HOW WE DO IT."